Urban Design Comments

Case Description: Discharge of condition 8 (Strategic Design Code) from Outline Planning Permission S/OUT/13/1555.	**Planning Ref**: S/COND/22/0031	
	Case Officer: Edward Snook	**UD Officer:** PG
Site: Land North Of A420, New Eastern Villages, Swindon.	**Relevant Policies**: DE1, DM1, NPPF, NMDC	
	Date: 25 February 2022	
Advice relating to NPPF, National Design Guide, National Model Design Code, Swindon Borough Local Plan Policy DE1 and Adopted Residential Design Guide SPD.		
Scheme recommended to Design Review Panel https://www.designreviewwest.org/		Yes

A - Summary	Complies	-	Conflicts	-	Changes Needed	X

Exec Summary	A clearer and consistent narrative is required to differentiate between 'mandatory' and 'flexible' requirements throughout the document. At the strategic scale, this design code needs to go beyond design guidance and focus on securing the strategic placemaking elements of the site-wide vision. The requirements set out in the SDC as mandatory requirements should essentially 'fix' the primary movement network, the strategic green infrastructure network, the local centre – key focal points, and set the strategic approach to achieving walkable, connected and distinctive neighbourhoods. The document currently doesn't make this distinction clearly enough, although the text does in many parts refer to requirements that 'must' be met, the range of mandatory requirements should in general be much simpler and clearly stated throughout. There needs to be more focus on some of the strategic elements of the development, such as the village centre and the primary street. With respect to the primary street I have suggested a table be produced to bring the various design, engineering, landscape and drainage requirements together.
B - Reasons	The requirement to produce a design code for Rowborough and S. Marston should in design terms: *a) Develop the vision, design concept, principles and frameworks described in the Design and Access Statement (February 2017);* *b) Identify the character areas across the site, including the design approach, character area identity and public realm;* *c) Explain how the design principles for the character areas including the local centres will be applied and co-ordinated across the site;* *(p20-23)* ***Design Vision*** - includes a series of good, generic sustainable urban development principles. It should take this opportunity to mention the nature of the vision for Rowborough as a series of distinctive neighbourhoods, and that they need to be designed in future character area codes in a way that delivers… • **Local centres / key groupings** – each neighbourhood settlement requires its own 'focal point' bringing together the various land uses as a collection of key groupings of built form, public facilities, public space and primary movement are arranged to establish the essential urban structure and over-arching character.

- **Walkable, connected and distinctive neighbourhoods** – the size, shape and structure of the villages / settlements needs to be set out in a way that can achieve a series of well-connected, walkable neighbourhoods. The defining characteristics set out by the code to expect the neighbourhood settlements to respond to landscape character, establishing 'key groupings' at nodal points in a way that establishes a strong sense of place.
- **Draw influences from landscape context** – integrating the rural local character with the development edges, enhancing the defining features of the surrounding rural landscape.

(p36) ***S. Marston Landscape Enhancement Plan*** - what are the mandatory requirements set out here in order to achieve the GI vision of the site? The plan currently refers to 'Opportunities' which are not required as mandatory.

(p38) ***Rowborough landscape enhancement strategy*** – same comment here. These important landscape enhancement strategies are key to the setting out of 'strategic' elements of the plan, and should be used at this scale to inform the character areas and future emerging urban form and its 'identity' – in response to this landscape character.

(p40) ***Rowborough Gate Landscape enhancement strategy*** – same comment as above. While the word 'must' is used often here, it still lies under 'opportunities' which can only be regarded as a 'potential' requirement, not a strategic 'fix' of the plan.

If the 'Green infrastructure parameter plan' is important in setting out the wider strategy, it should be clearly set out here and included and referred to in more detail throughout this section. Its specific drawing number should also be included for future ease of reference.

(P108) ***Village Centre*** – this is a very important section given the majority of the rest of Rowborough is set to solely provide residential use, this is the only aspect of 'Rowborough' that has a sense of true mixed use in what should be a vibrant, mixed-use urban neighbourhood character. As a vision for such a local centre, we would expect something similar to the following characteristics to be secured here:

Vision…

The village centre is to be designed as a compact, characterful and walkable mixed-use neighbourhood. The grouping of buildings and how they enclose and edge the public realm should be designed with the identity and character reminiscent of that found in historic village centres, with a compact, robust, tight-knit urban grain and form.

The village centre will be a well-connected, legible, easy-to-understand place that will prioritise pedestrians and cyclists within the village centre. The important public facilities and local centre uses will provide key 'landmarks' in the structuring of the layout, and key green infrastructure will be protected and enhanced through its positive integration into the village centre.

	Views out to the countryside will be enhanced by the integration of pedestrian movement routes and careful 'framing' in the alignment of paths towards such views / attractions. Mandatory design requirements should be set out within the strategic design code to provide the essential key ingredients and preconditions to achieve such a vision (or similar agreed). **Movement network** – important to set out as a mandatory requirement the need to achieve a connected and permeable structure to the entire development. (p78) ***Primary Streets*** – we need clear intent about its design, as a placemaking function of the wider development. Particularly its design approach through the core nodal areas. This strategic route needs to be designed as an integrated part of the village centre, performing a strong place function within the wider masterplan. A good balance between pedestrian and vehicular movement should be achieved. Mandatory requirements for the Primary Street (will change along its length) should be set out in a table format with the highways, drainage, landscape and urban design requirements included. This approach should make the document more user-friendly overall, and place all these requirements in the same location. Such requirements should include aspects such as: - **Carriageway width**…footpaths and cycleways. - **Bus route** – bus stops. - **Setback** - distance from back edge of footpath to building line. - **Design speed** (20mph) for a limited area around the local centre, 30mph outside of local centre. - **Tree-lined street** – formally laid out across length of primary street within local centre. (Species: example - Heavy Standard, Lime trees / London Plane?) - **Min Distance from tree to building line**- (Depending on tree species) to accommodate future tree growth, shadow zones etc. - **Access to properties** – establish whether or not direct vehicular access to residential properties will be acceptable? Access via secondary street, etc. - **Access to parking courts** - no direct access – via secondary street - **Pedestrian crossing** points (frequency) - **Vehicular swept paths** – for all vehicle types - **Built form scale** - taller buildings located along this route (within local centre) between 2-4 storeys, fronting the street, 3 storeys minimum height within key built form groupings / key spaces. - **Verge** - consistent grassed verge with parallel visitor parking spaces – both sides of carriageway (2.5m wide x 6m). Low-level planting within verge? - **Junction sightlines** – 2.4 x 33m? - **Junction radii** – 4m? - **Statutory services** – within footway each side

- **Street furniture** – lighting, signage, seating, cycle racks to be of a consistent palette, avoid clutter and designed to positively contribute to the quality of the street.

Combining this information into a single table will define the different street types along the Primary Street network in a way that collaboratively considers the different disciplines this document speaks to. It will also bring to life the requirements to deliver this important strategic aspect of the development and wider vision for Rowborough.

The use of precedent examples within document

Development on the former Ridgeway Farm site, Wiltshire – this scheme is a very mediocre-poor quality housing development in urban design terms. We should be aiming much higher in design quality for new development at Rowborough and South Marston. I suggest broadening the scope of precedent with more contemporary and successful development schemes such as:

Derwenthorpe, York (simple, traditional urban structure and architectural form throughout with a strong and effective contemporary interpretation, strong identity and character)

Nansledan, Newquay - although traditional, pastiche in its architecture, it has strong and very effective urban design layout principles. The primary street has very good active frontage, a strong building line and the housing / built form typologies appropriately increase and adapt to more mixed-use at the central key areas. Car parking is provided as a mix of types across the site without compromising the quality of the primary street. Mews streets and courtyards are carefully designed to allow a well-enclosed, active Primary Street.

Upton, Northampton

Distinctive identity and a really strong approach to street typologies incorporating sustainable drainage throughout is a strong aspect of this development. The primary street also relies on well-designed rear courtyards and a carefully designed public realm throughout, this development was also developed out through a design-coding process.

Cane Hill, Croydon

Two streets (rural and urban) on the same site, each with its own distinctive character and identity – consistent in its response to the role of each street and its intended character.

Precedents for local centre including retail and school

Lawley, Telford

While the 'detail' for the local centre is not sought now, the code should be clear about the need to establish a strong sense of character and identity and could require for example that any inactive areas of retail be 'wrapped' with frontage development – as is the case with the Morrisons supermarket in the image above (the retail box lies behind the mixed-use development.

Public buildings such as a new school should be incorporated into the design of the 'local' centre. Large areas of car parking should not interfere with the 'village centre' vision, but should rather support its placemaking ambition.

(P108) "4. Parking serving the retail uses to be integrated as part of the public realm."

This could rather read: *"local centre car parking areas must be discreetly designed, in most cases behind built form and all parking should be designed to support the streetscene."*

We need more principles in this section that refer generically to: building form, enclosure, scale, density and key buildings / groupings.

Primary Street

Discrepancy between how the primary street-section is set out on page 81 against the illustrative layout for the same street on page 104. The illustration on 104 would not be allowed if we were to use the coded section on page 81. Need to ensure consistency across the document.

	(p112) ***Key Places*** – the requirements for these spaces / areas should be more 'place' specific and include more information about the strategic 'role' of each of these areas. While their detail will come forward at the character area design code stage, it's important to be bold about what each of these spaces are meant to provide for the wider development. The idea of key built form 'groupings' to enable an enclosed public realm, the framing of distant views and the function of public realm should be made clearer. The 'village centre' illustration (for example) is accompanied by text that describes only the nature of the public highway and its junctions and crossings. It is crucial that the text also refers to urban design requirements to achieve the character and distinctiveness of these individual places, even though some of this text will be guiding the process at a generic scale at this stage.

These comments are not exhaustive but hope they are useful. I am happy to discuss any of these.

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URBAN DESIGN GROUP RECOGNISED PRACTITIONER

URBAN DESIGN GROUP

Finalist National UDG Awards 2017
Swindon Residential Design Guide SPD

RTPI AWARDS FOR PLANNING EXCELLENCE 2017

Joint Winner RTPI South West
Old Railway Quarter, Swindon